

**WINNING THEIR FAITH**
Prime Minister Modi being greeted in Dibrugarh, Assam, April 28, 2022

of Covid and the Ukraine war. He believes that the fundamentals of the India story remain strong and exudes confidence that his government will see the high growth it has set out to achieve. He wants to transform the economy. There is no going back on reforms."

**IF MODI 2.0 IS DIFFERENT, IT'S IN HOW THE PM HAS OVERCOME HESITANCIES OF HIS FIRST TERM AND INITIATED WIDESPREAD REFORM**

The impatience to effect radical change in his second term was evident in the beginning itself. Modi stunned Pakistan and the major powers of the world by abrogating Article 370 in August 2019 and ending the ambiguity over the question of Jammu and Kashmir being an integral part of India. In September that year, he announced that corporate tax would be slashed from 30 per cent to an average of 22 per cent, giving a huge stimulus to businesses. That was followed by the Supreme Court ruling in favour of building a Ram temple at Ayodhya, which put a firm lid on decades of strife over the disputed site. Home minister Amit Shah rammed through the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, or CAA, in Parliament, to make persecuted religious minorities who had migrated to India from Afghanistan, Pakistan and Bangladesh on or before December 31, 2014, eligible for Indian citizenship. This was open to those of all religions except Islam. While the move kicked up a storm and saw riots break out in Delhi, it shored up the government's core constituency.

Just when Modi seemed to have accomplished all that he had set out to do in the very first nine months of the new term, Covid came calling. Critics were quick to castigate him when he imposed a stringent lockdown that may have saved lives but knocked the bottom out of people's livelihoods. The poor handling of the second wave, characterised by the widespread shortage of oxygen, did no credit to his image. But Modi and his team learnt on the job, and made some remarkable progress in areas such as the availability of testing centres and kits, installing sufficient oxygen capacity to meet any fresh exigency and, most importantly, advancing vaccine research and tie-ups that led to India